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Advancing Transgender Inclusion in Indian Organisations: An Organisational Readiness Perspective from HR Professionals

Abstract

Purpose: This study aims to understand HR professionals' perception of the readiness of their organisations to implement transgender inclusive workplace practices, by examining the gap between willingness to change and the ability to change.

Design/methodology/approach: Qualitative exploratory approach was used to the 16 substantive semi-structured interview questions per respondent (HR01 – HR25) provided by the author. The accounts are from various sectors, positions and organisations. Reflexive, theory-informed thematic coding (based on Weiner's 2009 Organisational Readiness for Change Theory) was used for analysis. The file does not contain information on the dates of the interviews, the way in which they were recorded, nor ethical or consent issues, which are not assumed.

Findings: Six themes were developed, interrelated, but also recognising the need for ongoing accountability along the employee lifecycle: broad commitment with uneven local ownership; limited specialised HR capability; policies outpacing implementation; privacy, facilities and complaint-handling concerns; cross-functional and multi-site coordination; and ongoing accountability across the employee lifecycle. The accounts highlight a consistent disconnect between willingness and readiness to act – and differences across sectors and organisational structures.

Originality/value: The paper introduces the commitment–efficacy distinction to the practice of HR in India that is transgender inclusive, and suggests a framework for implementation that is based on leadership ownership, operational resources, confidential systems, local accountability and review. Findings rely on the accounts provided and cannot provide employee outcomes on its own.

Keywords: Transgender inclusion, organisational readiness, HRM, India, change commitment, change efficacy, qualitative research, policy implementation.

1. Introduction

Understanding symbolic and substantive organisational inclusion can be done in the light of classic scholarship on gendered organisations. Acker (1990, 2006) demonstrated how seemingly neutral structures can replicate inequalities in job design, in the embodied routines and norms. Kanter (1977) also pointed to the ways in which organisational structures impact opportunities and representation. The issue in this study is not whether or not a particular HR individual believes in equal treatment in theory, but whether recruitment portals, personnel systems, manager discretion, grievance processes and worksite facilities work in practice.

Recent published studies focus the problem. Sharma (2025) offers the most similar India-specific comparison as it analyses the challenges in the hiring process from HR professionals' perspectives. Even when organisations consider themselves supportive, HR systems and practices can reinforce binary assumptions in a study of transgender employees' transitions in The International Journal of Human Resource Management. While these studies highlight the importance of the organisational practices, the current analysis revolves around the perceived readiness to implement the practices throughout the employee lifecycle (Connell, 2010; Davis & Yeung, 2022; Mahajan et al., 2025).

An organisational readiness perspective is analytically useful as it helps to differentiate between supportive values and capabilities. There is no consensus among the respondents in terms of the level of institutional

readiness. Some say that they have dedicated policies and working safeguards, others say that they have generic equal-opportunity policies and little practical guidance. It queries about the impact of organisational contexts on the relationship between intention, infrastructure and everyday enacting of inclusive practices (Roberson, 2006; Shore et al., 2011, 2018).

Inequality can be perpetuated by seemingly innocuous routines in occupational norms and employment structures (Ashcraft, 2013; Bailyn, 1993; Stryker, 2008). These concerns are relevant when employment systems are based on a binary gender system.

Inclusion of transgender in employment is more than simply a statement of equality. The recruitment and promotion criteria, personnel records, grievance arrangements, facilities, staff training and supervisor decisions can all impact upon the dignity and fair treatment an employee may feel in their day-to-day work. Even if an organisation has an approved policy, this does not necessarily mean that it is followed in practice, especially when the organisation has multiple locations, shifts, project teams or contractors.

The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019 and the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Rules, 2020 are important pieces of legislation in India for non-discrimination and responsibilities for organisations. The Rules cover equal opportunity policies, facilities, confidentiality and grievance. This is especially the case for the operational capacity of HR departments and management as a whole (Government of India, 2019, 2020).

A 25 respondent accounts are analysed in the paper. Each account includes background information and responses to 16 typical interview questions. This manuscript is written as if it were an independent qualitative data set provided, without claiming independent verification of how the interviews were conducted or how the organisations were run. The aim is to gain an evidence-based interpretation of the HR professionals' perceptions, rather than an estimate of organisational readiness that is representative of a statistical sample.

2. Literature Review and Conceptual Orientation

2.1. Non-discrimination policy to implementation

Policies are a way of indicating an employer's formal stance and inclusion is dependent on the working of specific processes. Job ads can be inclusive, but background checks are not flexible; there can be a central awareness training facility, but no guidance for frontline supervisors; and there can be a lack of awareness among frontline supervisors. In the Indian context, it becomes imperative to take into account policy content, workplace facilities, complaint officers and confidentiality together (Government of India, 2020). All these issues combine to create a multi-actor organisational challenge for implementation, not just an HR communication challenge.

2.2. Organisational Readiness for Change Theory

Weiner (2009) defines organisational readiness for change in two interrelated aspects: change commitment (the shared desire to change the proposed change) and change efficacy (the shared self-efficacy to change the proposed change). Factors that influence readiness include perceived task demands, resources, situational factors and the value attributed to the change. For the purposes of this study, the responses of support, priorities and sponsorship are taken as indicators of the respondents' perceptions of commitment. Training, procedures, accessible reporting channels, system flexibility and local implementation are considered relevant aspects of reports, as they are related to perceived efficacy.

One key conceptual constraint is that readiness is an organisational, collective phenomenon. These data are individual HR accounts, seemingly from a variety of organisations. For this reason, the perceived organisational readiness is reported, rather than a psychometrically measured shared readiness score. Shea et al. (2014) offer a parallel description of the measurement of readiness; however, the ORIC scale was not used and no quantitative claims are made.

2.3. Inclusion, diversity climate and organisational routines

Inclusion is more than diversity in numbers or a non-discriminatory attitude. Mor Barak (2015) and Roberson (2006) think about inclusion in the context of meaningful participation and organisational access. While Shore et al. (2011) highlight that the need for belonging does not preclude the need for uniqueness, Shore et al. (2018) link inclusive workplaces to leadership, practices and the wider organisational context. Previous studies on diversity climate suggest that what employers do and what employees see and think about the programmes may not align (Kossek & Zonia, 1993; Nishii, 2013). The current data set includes correlated tensions: Centrally stated commitments are reported by the organisations, but the respondents doubt that site managers are aware of or fulfil the expectations.

According to Acker (1990, 2006) formally standardised systems can create inequality. This is essential when respondents talk about electronic identity records, documentation mismatches, or facility access or administrative rules that have not been thought of in terms of gender. Ahmed (2012) also warns of the possibility of institutional language of diversity and practices that undermine it. Benschop (2001) and Benschop and Verloo (2011) take a management and organisational-change approach to inclusion work, seeing it as an institutional rather than one-off training process. The research does not presume that all cases of incongruence reflect underlying antagonism; incongruence in design, coordination and accountability are analytically important.

2.4. Stigma, disclosure, privacy and organisational safety.

Stigma is another issue involved in transgender inclusion at the workplace. Conceptual explanations of stigma-related stress include those of Meyer (2003), Hatzenbuehler (2009) and Herek (2009); Ragins (2008) and Ragins et al. (2007) demonstrate the significance of disclosure concerns in the workplace. Confidential reporting, secure handling of identity information, are practical responsibilities mentioned in the respondent accounts. This concern is furthered by Connell (2012) for the workplace risks of disclosure and Herman (2013) provides an example of how this is related to dignity and perceived safety in terms of infrastructure and regulating gendered spaces. These frameworks help to understand confidentiality as an enabling condition, rather than an administrative matter, for substantive inclusion.

Employee accounts of support, moreover, also warn against the temptation to make claims about what happens to transgender employees. Brewster et al. (2012), McFadden (2015), Thoroughgood et al. (2017) and Davis and Yeung (2022) recognise the significance of workplace experiences, discrimination and supportive systems. Grant et al. (2011) report a broader structural discrimination in a US context, which cannot be transferred to India but which serves to illustrate the need for paying attention to employment processes in addition to personal attitudes. Bauer et al. (2015) is pertinent to the question of the stakes of structural support, but does not provide any evidence directly related to any of the organisations in the current sample. The file currently only includes HR views, and cannot determine actual transgender employee well-being or safety.

2.5. Change readiness, multilevel action and implementation accountability

Weiner (2009) differentiates between shared commitment and shared efficacy and Shea et al. (2014) operationalise these in a different implementation context through an organisational readiness measure. According to Oreg et al. (2011) contextual factors and process factors influence reactions to change. Schneider et al. (2013) highlight the processes that are involved in the development and maintenance of organisational climate and culture. Multilevel theory also warns that individual-level responses do not necessarily represent the collective level capability of the organisation (Kozlowski & Klein, 2000). For this reason, the results presented herein are in the form of HR professionals' perceptions, rather than validated firm-level readiness scores.

The second caution comes from the literature about diversity programmes. Kalev et al. (2006) distinguish between programmes that are assumed to have an impact, and managerial structures. Ely and Thomas (2001), Thomas and Ely (1996) and Nkomo and Cox (1996) make a link between diversity and learning, identity and organisational processes. Additionally, the meaning of support can be practice and implementation dependent, as suggested by Button (2001), Day and Schoenrade (2000), Colgan et al. (2009) and Fletcher and Everly (2021). This leads to a focus on how easy it is to complain, how consistent the front line is, how well it is managed and whether it is continually reviewed.

2.6. Research gap, novelty and contribution

There are differentiated comparators from recent studies. Managing the hesitation of managers in India is explored by Sharma (2025); Mahajan et al. (2025) explore the experiences of LGBTQIA+ individuals in urban India, and Priyanka and Bansal (2025) explore workplace inclusivity in Delhi. In 2026, Chaloryoo and Chatterjee discuss the contextual factors that affect policy development in Thailand and the need to consider external and internal factors when implementing policies. Davis and Yeung (2022) have written a systematic review that summarises transgender equity in the workplace. Together, these publications inspire the proposed contribution: Perceived gap between change commitment and change efficacy in practice in the context of heterogeneous Indian organisations. Chaloryoo and Chatterjee (2026) make further differentiations between internal and external antecedents of policy design. This data does not provide a new general theory, but rather allows for a theory-informed interpretation of an HR-only data set. Inclusion is discussed in the context of broader workplace relationships in studies on workplace discrimination and microaggressions (Deitch et al., 2003; Dhanani et al., 2018; Sue et al., 2007).

While there are Indian studies that have already proven that transgender inclusion is a crucial employment and HR issue, the present study poses a different question. Sharma (2025) explores managerial resistance to employing transgender individuals, while Mahajan et al. (2025) explore the experiences of LGBTQIA+ people in urban India, and Priyanka and Bansal (2025) explore the inclusivity of the workplace in Delhi. Those contributions relate to barriers/experiences and policy implementation. They do not, however, provide the same cross-sector picture of what HR professionals see as their organisations' readiness to engage in transgender inclusion and their perceived ability to do so. Therefore, there is no claim of novelty of either the use of HR perspectives or the Indian setting.

The first gap relates to the theoretical one of using an explicitly differentiated readiness lens. Organisational Readiness for Change Theory makes a distinction between commitment to change and efficacy of change (Weiner, 2009), but having a positive attitude towards transgender employment does not mean that HR systems, line managers, facilities, record handling processes and confidential complaint mechanisms are able to provide inclusion. Combining these dimensions provides a more specific explanation as to how positive commitments can exist alongside organisational implementation challenges. The data are made up of

individual HR accounts and therefore do not measure a collective state of the organisation (Kozlowski & Klein, 2000; Shea et al., 2014).

The second is a gap of context and comparison. Evidence from specific workplaces or locations does not necessarily account for differences in readiness challenges across distributed services, industrial sites and multi-branch institutions and smaller firms. The 25 accounts in this study cover various sector and organisational types of Indian companies, and allow for a bounded comparison of perceived constraints like specialist training, legacy information systems, outsourced employment, operational supervision and administrative delay. The study does not argue for statistical differences between sectors or representativeness, but rather to find patterns and differences in the reported implementation circumstances.

The third gap is on the implementation side. Research and organisational reporting can focus on the adoption of policy, the commitment to recruitment or individual experiences and not necessarily show how inclusion is operationalised in the normal HR processes of recruiting, supporting, protecting and developing employees. The results of this study show a relationship between reported leadership commitment and HR capability and recruitment systems, employee records, privacy safeguards, grievance access, workplace facilities, local management discretion and career progression. The policy–practice gap is therefore regarded as a task allocation and operational capacity and review question, not just a policy word question.

The study thus has three "bounded" contributions. Theoretically, it applies the commitment–efficacy dichotomy to understand expressed readiness for transgender inclusion. Empirically, it brings together 25 HR accounts from across the sectors to find similarities and differences in perceived barriers and enablers to implementation. It offers a provisional framework for readiness to implement in practice, with leadership ownership, specialist capability, policy translation, site-level action and ongoing review. They are not evidence of the effectiveness of a programme or of compliance of an organisation, nor of the lived experience of transgender employees, but are analytical contributions based on qualitative accounts provided.

2.7. Research questions

RQ1. What is HR's language around change commitment and change efficacy relating to transgender inclusion in their organisations?

RQ2. What are the reported conditions that facilitate or hinder implementation (organisational, procedural and contextual)?

RQ3. What are the policy–practice gaps that emerge in the accounts and what theory-informed readiness framework emerges from the gaps?

3. Methodology

3.1. Research approach and design

This study is qualitative, exploratory and follows an interpretivist approach. Each HR professional's written organisational readiness account is the unit of analysis. The analysis is focused on experiences, perceptions and explanations, not statistical testing of hypotheses or estimating the national prevalence. The semi-structured interview schedule includes awareness, leadership commitment, capability, HR policies, implementation, barriers and improvements.

3.2. Dataset, sampling and participant profile

A 25 respondent records coded HR01, HR02, HR23, HR24, HR25, etc., were collected by the researcher. The provided corpus has 400 question-level responses, each record has a role, self-described gender, years of HR experience, approximate workforce size, policy description and answers to 16 substantive questions. The preceding research plan stated that the sampling method was purposive sampling with maximum variation, and the diversity of positions and sectors in the file was in line with the purpose of the research, but it was not mentioned in the file whether the recruitment process was done in accordance with the procedure, and it could not be confirmed independently.

The professional profiles and the descriptions of organisations' policies are summarised in Table 1. The number of years of experience varies from 3 to 18 years (median 10 years) and the size of the organisation's workforce (as reported in the supplied profiles) is anywhere between 160 and 12,000 employees. Gender information is provided as 13 female, 11 male and 1 non-binary. These are attributes that have been mentioned in the provided narratives and not verified HR information. The sample includes financial services, technology, manufacturing, retail, BPO, hospitality, healthcare, logistics, consulting, education and construction and others.

Table 1

Respondent Characteristics and Reported Policy Status

ID	Professional role/sector	Experience	Policy context
HR01	DEI Lead, Banking and Financial Services	11 years	Detailed inclusion policy; uneven implementation across branches
HR02	HR Manager, Information Technology (IT)	9 years	General diversity policy; transgender-specific procedures are being developed.
HR03	HR Executive, Manufacturing	4 years	General equal opportunity statement that does not include a transgender specific inclusion policy.
HR04	Talent Acquisition Specialist, Financial Services	7 years	General diversity policy; selected transgender-specific measures
HR05	Employee Relations Officer (Retail & E-commerce)	11 years	Overall diversity policy with variations in each location.
HR06	DEI Programme Lead, Business-Process Outsourcing	12 years	Equal-opportunity policy that includes transgender persons.

HR07	HR Generalist, Hospitality	6 years	No specific inclusion policy beyond general conduct rules
HR08	HR Business Partner (Healthcare Services)	10 years	General diversity policy; limited transgender-specific procedures
HR09	HR Manager (Logistics and Warehousing)	14 years	The general non-discrimination policy without a detailed implementation plan.
HR10	Digital Commerce Senior HR and People Operations Manager	8 years	General inclusion policy; transgender-specific provisions being drafted
HR11	Talent Acquisition Specialist - E-commerce Logistics	5 years	General diversity statement and guidance for hiring pilots.
HR12	HR Business Partner, Private Hospital Network	12 years	A policy that is equal opportunity and has limited specific procedure.
HR13	Plant HR Manager, Automobile Manufacturing	16 years	general non-discrimination policy.
HR14	People Operations Manager, SaaS Start-up	7 years	Flexible HR systems and written guidance that is transgender-inclusive.
HR15	HR Officer, Supermarket Retail Chain	3 years	No transgender specific procedure has been documented.
HR16	Multinational Consulting, DEI Programme Manager.	14 years	formal inclusion policy and training programme is in place.
HR17	Manager, Employee Relations, Hospitality and Hotels	10 years	An inclusion toolkit is under consideration for use with the general conduct policy.
HR18	HR Generalist, Higher Education	6 years	general equal-opportunity rules.

HR19	Regional HR Head - Telecommunications	18 years	General diversity policy that does not necessarily cover contractors.
HR20	Pharmaceutical Research- Recruitment Manager	9 years	Implementing a non-discrimination policy and providing further information to managers.
HR21	HR Compliance Manager – Infrastructure and Construction	13 years	without a specific inclusion plan, mandatory conduct policy.
HR22	People and Culture Head, Media and Advertising	15 years	Public inclusion commitment with partly formalised procedures.
HR23	HR Executive, Agribusiness and Food Processing	4 years	General workplace conduct policy
HR24	Senior HR Manager for a Public-Sector Financial Institution	17 years	A formal equal-opportunity system that is characterized by slow administrative changes.
HR25	DEI and HR Policy Adviser, Professional Services.	8 years	inclusive policy, processes of escalation and periodic review.

Note. The data on participant characteristics and policy status are taken from the HR01–HR25 data provided. The number of workers is self-reported and not independently verified. Based on researcher-provided interview responses (HR01–HR25).

3.3. Interview guide and Data collection documentation

The 16-question interview schedule is divided into sections: awareness (Q1 – Q2), commitment (Q3 – Q5), capacity (Q6 – Q8), policies and implementation (Q9 – Q11), and barriers and enablers (Q12 – Q13) and recommendations (Q14 – Q15) and closing reflections (Q16). There are five preliminary profile items that describe participants' professional background. It was planned in the original protocol to have interviews of approximately 40-60 minutes. The file provided however includes written responses and lacks information regarding the dates, length, platform, and the process of audio recording, transcripts and invitations to participate in the recruitment process. Those details should be provided from the fieldwork records and not made up afterwards for a final empirical journal submission.

3.4. Analytical approach and trustworthiness

Responses provided were compared both within and between codes using reflexive thematic analysis as outlined by Braun and Clarke (2006, 2022). All 25 accounts were read in conjunction with the interview

domains as a first step. Second, descriptive codes were created based on the concepts of leadership ownership, staff awareness, HR training, privacy, facilities, documentation, site-level variation, and contractor coverage and implementation monitoring. Thirdly, codes related to each other were combined across cases and grouped into themes. Fourth, the themes were further developed with the help of contrasting cases, for example, HR06, HR14, HR16 and HR25 are more developed than HR03, HR07, HR15 and HR23. Fifth, themes were interpreted in the light of change commitment and change efficacy, whilst inductively identified issues, such as outsourced labour and frontline settings were retained.

Interpretation was checked against the written responses under the participant identifiers. Quoted passages are from the provided file and are referenced by the respondent code and question number. No inter-coder reliability coefficient, software-assisted audit, member checking or transcript verification are claimed due to the lack of documentation of these steps. The analytical record can be enhanced by keeping the codebook, extracts and researcher reflexive notes with the final data set to make it more auditable.

3.5. Epistemological position and researcher reflexivity.

An interpretivist approach is suitable as the interviews are asking for evaluations of preparedness, perceived constraints and organisational meaning, and not a directly observed causal process (Creswell & Poth, 2018; Flick, 2018). Respondents' accounts are located statements: a central DEI lead might focus on the policy infrastructure, a site-level HR professional might focus on day-to-day supervision. This discrepancy does not imply that either of the accounts is incorrect. The analysis is based on the participant's responsibilities and reported organisational circumstances, and how they impact the meaning of readiness is contrasted. Reflexive thematic analysis acknowledges that the researcher is not a passive extractor of naturally occurring patterns of meaning, but rather plays an active role in developing patterns of meaning (Braun & Clarke, 2019, 2021, 2022).

The data was provided in the form of written answers to a standardised guide. Since there were no recordings or transcriptions of spontaneous conversation with the file, the researcher cannot say that he/she has analysed the pauses, probing sequences, interactional detail or interview dynamics. Roulston (2010) highlights the importance of the methodological aspects of the production of interview interaction. The format here thus allows systematic interpretation of written accounts, but it has the disadvantage of being unable to make claims regarding the depth of the interviews, and of not being able to verify how the answers were elicited. When no supporting records exist, no claim is made that a formal pilot, inter-coder meeting or participant validation was completed by a formal pilot.

3.6. Analytic logic and quality criteria

The coding approach was theoretically driven with a focus on commitment and efficacy, but also inductive by taking into account the administrative difficulties, operational variation and respondent priorities. Fereday and Muir-Cochrane (2006) provide some directions on how to use deductive and inductive thematic reasoning, but in the present analysis, the reflexive thematic interpretation is used, and coding agreement is not taken as a measure of truth. Boeije (2002) agrees about the usefulness of constant comparison within cases and Hsieh and Shannon (2005) aid in the differentiation of direct, conventional and theory-directed approaches to qualitative material. It was not to list out the individual words but to compare the implication of a response on organisational readiness.

The number of samples collected (25) does not necessarily indicate saturation. Guest et al. (2006), Saunders et al. (2018) and Malterud et al. (2016) discuss different approaches to sample adequacy and saturation and Braun and Clarke (2021) warn against saturation being a necessary threshold for reflexive thematic analysis.

The range of sectors and roles is a good feature in order to provide contrasts but it highlights the fact that there is not the depth of the study possible if it had been limited to a single sector. Transferability is therefore based on the level of description and the clear boundaries, not the number of representativeness (Lincoln & Guba, 1985; Yin, 2018).

There are various purposes of qualitative traditions. Charmaz (2014) talks about the construction of theory from detailed empirical engagement and van Maanen (1979) defends the explanatory role of the interpretive research of organisations. The more modest claim to be made in this paper is that of pattern interpretation in the light of theory. It does not refer to its findings as grounded theory as the short written accounts and record of analysis available do not substantiate the procedures necessary for this claim.

3.7. Ethical considerations and reporting limits

No ethics committee approval, participant information sheets, consent forms, records of participant recruitment or evidence of confidentiality arrangements are provided. So this paper can't say that those procedures had been done. The actual approval/exemption details for journal submission should replace the above details and consent and withdrawal procedures should be explained, as well as identities of the participants and consent to use of quotes. Codes used here are codes of the respondents and names of the organisation or individual(s) are not mentioned.

4. Findings

Table 2 is a summary of the six themes and respondent anchors. 25 accounts were given and 6 themes were created. It is assumed that the statements made by respondents are a reflection of the professional perceptions and not of independent verification of the practices described in the organisations. The themes overlap in practice but the differences offer some explanation as to where willingness is or isn't matched by capability to implement.

Table 2

Cross-Case Thematic Synthesis and Supporting Respondent Accounts

Theme	Source anchor	Interpretive meaning
Commitment vs operational ownership	HR01 Q4, HR06 Q4, HR10 Q4, HR16 Q4, HR25 Q4	Leadership support, policy approval, resources and assignment of responsibility
Specialist implementation capability	HR02 Q6–Q8, HR03 Q6–Q8, HR14 Q6–Q8, HR24 Q6–Q8	Skills, systems and usable procedures are context specific
Policy–practice discontinuity	HR05 Q11, HR11 Q11, HR18 Q11, HR19 Q11	Central policy does not necessarily apply to local work arrangements.
Confidentiality and remedies	HR05 Q8, HR08 Q8, HR12 Q8, HR21 Q8	The need to have access to credible confidential escalation is still critical.
Distributed operational responsibility	HR09 Q10–Q13, HR19 Q10–Q13, HR21 Q10–Q13	Communication between site, contractor and supervising

		personnel.
Continuous lifecycle review	HR06 Q14–Q16, HR11 Q14–Q16, HR25 Q14–Q16	Retention and promotion from recruitment to the end of the process.

Note. Respondent codes are used to refer to qualitative accounts, not population prevalence. Source: Author's thematic synthesis of HR01–HR25 responses.

4.1. Supportive intentions don't always result in local ownership.

There are many examples of managers who are generally positive about inclusion but who do not have a clear definition of inclusion and/or rely on individual supervisors to implement it. HR01 is supportive senior leadership; not all locations have equal levels of interest; HR19 is regional priorities which can affect implementation of the diversity objectives which have been approved centrally. HR10 says that HR formalisation is hampered by a small HR team (HR10, Q3) and HR24 states that there are delays because of administrative processes. These accounts indicate that providing support at the top does not necessarily provide effective commitment across an organisational hierarchy.

However, there are differences for the better. HR06 is a statement of senior management commitment, which includes "written policies, training resources and formal accountability" (HR06, Q4). HR16 contains formal resources and monitoring and HR25 contains policy approval, resource allocation and monitoring. More advanced accounts, however, also recognize that there are inconsistencies at the team level, and that accountability needs to go beyond the policy level. The pattern is similar to Weiner's change commitment construct, but the pattern indicates that the extent of the distribution of commitment to the implementing units should be considered.

4.2. The overall HR competence is more than the specialist inclusion competence.

Delegates frequently report that they have other skills in employee relations, recruitment/compliance but not in-depth skills in transgender inclusion. HR03 says that our HR department is not fully prepared, there is limited specialised procedures and training (HR03, Q6). HR08 also has a good score for preparation for general employment issues, but requires more detailed guidance, and HR20 scores high for structured recruitment and low for specialist knowledge. HR21 is general level of compliance with some specialist preparation.

Resources and deployment makes a difference. HR14 refers to more flexibility in the procedures of a small technology organisation and HR24 to more formalised administrative systems, which are not easily changed quickly. HR02 is an indicator of a need to update employee records and confidentiality practices and HR04 is an indicator of interviewer training. All of these responses indicate that there are a number of attributes of a firm that are associated with being effective. It is dependent on the task requirements, information systems, front line skills and specialist support.

4.3. Although there are formal policies, there is not consistent implementation.

The policy – practice gap is a clear theme that is present throughout the content. HR01 states that Corporate policies may be broad, but branch-level knowledge and resources may not be uniform (HR01, Q11). HR05 suggests "consistency in the central policies and inconsistency in the stores practices" and HR17 suggests "inconsistency across the hotel properties" and HR19 suggests "lack of carry over of the corporate expectations to outsourced operations. HR22 is positive on intentions, but less positive in written procedures

of inclusion, HR18 positive in developed academic discussion of inclusion, less positive in employment practices.

A few of the respondents cite the risk of inclusive recruitment and not inclusive employment. Inclusive recruitment messages are not always followed by adequate workplace preparation (HR11, Q11) and HR04 says there is uncertainty among hiring managers. HR06 and HR25, who have created policies in accordance with their profile, are still indicating the need for more training for supervisors and the consistent application of the policies. Therefore, policy alone is not a good proxy for the quality of implementation, in the absence of worksite-level procedures and feedback.

4.4. Core readiness tests are confidentiality, complaints and facilities.

The confidentiality of reporting is consistently stressed and the safe handling of employee information. Employees may be hesitant to utilise complaint processes if they believe they will not be confidential (HR05, Q8). HR12 is about risks in close knit departments, HR21 and HR09 are barriers to site level confidential access. With a small staff that's easy to reach, as HR10 says, it's not easy to keep personal information contained. These accounts do not address individual breaches, but rather situations where there may be a loss of faith in grievance systems.

The physical facilities and documentation, especially in manufacturing, construction, logistics and hospitality also determine capacity. HR13 contains facility assessments, HR21 references to temporary project-site facilities, HR03 references to physical infrastructure as a possible challenge and HR08 references to record and privacy needs in healthcare. The results show that inclusive implementation needs to be implemented through interpersonal safeguards as well as physical and/or digital implementation. This is in line with the focus on policies, facilities and complaints procedures in India's 2020 Rules.

4.5. Problems with execution because of multi-site operations and third parties

All the accounts reveal a mismatch between the HR systems in companies and the work environment. HR09 deems implementation to be largely dependent on site supervisors (HR09, Q10) and HR19 says that central diversity policies do not always trickle down to outsourced operations. The same applies to HR21 where HR and project managers are called the "daily implementers". HR01, HR05 and HR17 are indicators of branch differences, store and hotel differences. The cases make the point that contractors, branches and local supervisors are active parts of the organisational readiness and not to be assumed to be “under the wing” of central HR.

There are a number of proposed enablers which are clearly cross-functional. HR02 states that HR, IT, legal and senior management should be engaged, HR11 states there should be coordinated recruitment and operations planning, HR13 states that there should be engagement with worker representatives, and HR19 states that there should be contractual expectations. In practical terms, change efficacy will be contingent on the ability of the organisation to co-ordinate a number of units and work arrangements around a common standard.

4.6. Throughout the life cycle, sustainable readiness should be continually reviewed and covered.

Respondents do not think that awareness sessions or publication of policies are an end point. After the policy is introduced, sustainable inclusion must be continually monitored (HR06, Q16). HR16 recommends that the experience of employees should be evaluated on a regular basis and HR25 recommends that there should be periodic readiness reviews and improvements based on feedback. HR14 emphasises frequent management

development, HR24 management record systems and management instructions need to be modified. The following accounts think of readiness as something that needs to be maintained and adapted.

Development and normal employee experience is another trend to consider which involves employees from recruitment to retention. HR11 says success isn't only about the number of appointments and needs to factor in retention and development, HR20 focuses more on career development. HR01 says that it is crucial to consider employee experiences, rather than the number of policies. These accounts indicate that ongoing monitoring should be directed towards the processes that are working and the capacity of staff to do so rather than just towards inclusion activities completed.

5. Discussion

5.1. Theoretical significance

The distinction between commitment and capability, both of which are declared, is the first theoretical contribution. Members of the organisation can appreciate the change but they are uncertain of the resources and the tasks to be performed, according to Weiner (2009). This disconnection is especially pertinent where a manager is proactively encouraging Equal Opportunities and lacks a strong system of record, facilities and complaints/contractor coordination. We don't break these down into one readiness score: these are each individual indicators of possible implementation. Shea et al. (2014) provide a helpful measurement reference for future research, but the evidence in this study (HR only) does not support using an organisational readiness scale in a retrospective manner or the psychometric validation of this scale in this context.

The second is to consider readiness as spread out over an employee lifecycle. While often the first process that can be seen is the recruitment process, record changes, shift allocation, facilities, reporting and advancement can be different bottleneck processes as indicated by the responses. This is in line with the literature on gendered systems and inequality regimes (Acker, 1990, 2006), institutional diversity (Ahmed, 2012) and inclusive climate in workplaces (Nishii, 2013; Shore et al., 2018). Contribution is not so much about demonstrating that one particular intervention equals one particular employee outcome, but conceptual integration in the Indian HR context.

Thirdly, the data show a pragmatic balance between flexibility and predictability. In some instances, informal processes may not provide the employee with the same level of privacy and/or may result in inconsistent decisions, and small, entrepreneurial organisations may make rapid changes in practices. This delay in policy revision can be in very structured organisations, where there might be complaint and compliance procedures. Flexibility is insufficient, as is formalisation. A viable implementation model thus must be both adaptively responsive as well as written safeguards. This proposition should be investigated in the future, for example in a before/after comparison of HR processes, before and after an inclusion initiative (Schneider et al., 2013; Oreg et al., 2011).

5.2. No stereotyping of sectors – differentiation in the sector.

Facilities, safety, supervisors and worksites as described by HR03, HR13, HR21 and HR23 is an issue in industrial and infrastructure settings. Respondents working in financial services or professional services are more likely to report having formal policies, systems, privacy and branch consistency (HR01, HR04, HR16, HR24 and HR25). Retail and hospitality measures in perspective, high turnover and customer-facing interactions (HR05, HR07, HR15 and HR17). However, the study is not able to rank sectors as only a small number of respondents represent each sector and their accounts are not validated as representative. This is not to be understood as differences but rather as hypotheses for further research in the context.

The descriptions of the respondents also indicate that the individual manager should not be the only one blamed for implementation issues. A hiring manager might not be able to correct third party forms or have the capital available for facilities, a corporate HR team may be unable to guarantee the behaviour of a daily agency supervisor. The coordination problem includes decision rights, supplier contracts, information systems and physical environment. This widens the scope of readiness to encompass more than just attitudes, but still highlights leadership and staff confidence (Kalev et al., 2006 and Kozlowski & Klein, 2000).

One of the most critical things to keep in mind is that inclusion-oriented management is not able to assume that the employee population is uniform. Shore et al. (2011) and Ely and Thomas (2001) are included in group processes and organisational learning, while Bowleg (2012) cautions against analyses which "mask the intersections of disadvantage. Additional findings from the existing literature on identity and careers (McFadden, 2015; Fletcher & Everly, 2021) also indicate that the employment journey is important beyond employment, however, it is not possible to assess careers over time.

The results suggest that there is a gap between intentions to support transgender inclusion and the systems in place to support transgender inclusion. This is a direct reflection on Weiner's (2009) readiness model in which the commitment to change can be relatively strong, but the efficacy to change can be in doubt. Supportive leadership does not always equal trained supervisors, specialist procedures, easily accessible confidential grievance systems and up-to-date employee records in the accounts provided. It is particularly evident in distributed organisations, central intentions and local discretion, turnover and third party arrangements.

The data also indicates some important differences – no one story of readiness. HR06, HR14, HR16 and HR25 are more complex policy or HR support contexts which each indicate areas of need or opportunity. HR03, HR07, HR15 and HR23, on the other hand, are specific procedures and training to a certain extent. Another challenge for HR24 is the fact that they have an established administrative system which is not very responsive. Such contradictory reports caution that size of the company or the existence of a general goodwill or formal policy is not enough to determine the level of preparedness.

The analysis provides an implementation angle to the research on managerial hesitation in India (Sharma, 2025). Support can make a difference, but administrative and infrastructure issues may still arise and there may be hesitation and stereotypes. Firstly, it will be to move transgender inclusion from a one-off to a coordinated change-management initiative that will require the involvement of leadership, HR, IT, operations, compliance and vendors/contractors. It's not only about the attitudes of managers towards inclusion, it's about whether the systems that employees interact with the organisation can be inclusive and fair.

5.3. Proposed readiness and implementation framework for organisations

The suggested roadmap to readiness to implementation is illustrated in Figure 1. There are 5 elements of a theory-informed framework that are interrelated. First, commitment means that there must be explicit prioritisation, that there must be leadership sponsorship and that there must be responsible decision-makers. Secondly, efficacy of change is linked to resources, HR capacity and supervision, adaptable information systems and facilities. Third, policy translation is the process of translating the procedures for recruitment, record keeping, confidentiality, grievance procedures, career advancements and site operations. Finally, implementation coverage is the consistent procedures of units, shifts, branches, contractors and vendors. Fifth, learning and accountability is a process that must be periodically reviewed, feedback from employees, complaints followed-up and ineffective processes modified. It is a conceptual mixture of interview descriptions and not a statistically tested causal model.

Figure 1

Proposed Organisational Readiness-to-Implementation Pathway for Transgender Inclusion

Commitment: explicit prioritisation, leadership sponsorship and responsible decision-makers

↓

Change efficacy: resources, HR capacity and supervision, adaptable information systems and facilities

↓

Policy translation: recruitment, record keeping, confidentiality, grievance procedures, career advancements and site operations

↓

Implementation coverage: consistent procedures of units, shifts, branches, contractors and vendors

↓

Learning and accountability: periodic review, employee feedback, complaint follow-up and modified ineffective processes

Note. Organisational Readiness for Change Theory (Weiner, 2009) informed conceptual sequence based on the thematic interpretation of HR01 – HR25. Arrows are NOT empirical estimates of causal effects. Author's conceptual synthesis.

5.4. Practical implications

Indian organisations can start with a documented review of the entire employee journey, starting from the application fields and job related selection, to onboarding, privacy, facilities, complaint reporting and progression. There should be a policy owner at corporate and site level and managers should be trained in a situation based manner, according to their role. If your organisation has outsourced workers, you need to make sure that your contractual requirements and reporting lines cover the outsourced workers. It can be a formal procedure as short and sweet as possible for small businesses or more extensive audits of branches, vendors and legacy systems for large organisations. These measures are intended to help close the gap between policy and observable and accessible practices.

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6. Limitations and Future Research

Geographical distribution, organisation identifiers, dates or verbatim recording transcripts are not included in the original material. So, no effort has been made to make regional interpretations or to make interpretations over time. The question–answer format may result in socially desirable and brief answers, and thus may not give opportunities to discuss contradictory experiences, which may be normatively appropriate. The researcher also gave the data set as gathered material, without independently verifiable evidence of recruiting and/or consent in the attachment. These do not mean that they cannot be reported, but they do not mean that there is a reason to make up methodological procedures. Any presentation should have statements that are valid and that the presenter can support.

A better follow-on design would have been to have more than one organisational informant and transgender workers, but not to have required them to reveal their identity to other workers or to researchers unless they had consented to this. Examples of confidential policy audits are: job postings, applications, complaints processes, employee-record updates and facilities guidance and progression processes. The one HR

perspective per organisation is not a strong explanation, a comparison of documentary evidence and participant accounts and implementation examples would be more appropriate. There would also be a depth of interpretation due to the reflexive consideration of the researcher's access, assumptions, and role (Charmaz, 2014; Lincoln & Guba, 1985; Roulston, 2010).

Additional comparative studies might examine whether there is a relationship between perceived readiness and completion of any specific implementation task, whether there is a relationship between the governance structure and the size of the organisation, or whether having control over the contractor increases consistency. While the present data set does not enable sub-group analysis by intersection, an intersectional perspective is important as gender identity is intersected with class, caste, disability and employment arrangements (Bowleg, 2012). Future follow-up studies could include an organisational change commitment measure and efficacy measure as well as outcomes as measured by transgender employees. Any tests should be designed to differentiate between individuals and organisations and have sufficient power to perform the type of analysis (Kozlowski & Klein, 2000; Shea et al., 2014).

Moreover, the voices of the participants are from an HR perspective – the lived experience of transgender employees is not directly represented. The sample is not statistically representative, but is rather a purposive sample and the accounts are from diverse sectors with limited within organisation triangulation. The common structured questions may also have an impact on the recurring issues. Future research should include multiple informants in organisations, include transgender employees if ethically feasible and examine the differences between organisations over time and when examining actual policy artefacts. The quantitative future would change the measurement of readiness, but have to take into account the collective nature of readiness (Shea et al., 2014).

7. Conclusion

The 25 HR accounts suggest that it is not necessarily the lack of support for transgender inclusion that is the issue, but the inability of this support to become a sustainable organisational capacity. Across the sectors, training, follow-up, reporting, procedures, leadership and accountability, and local practice and follow-up are mentioned as specialist training. However, readiness is not a policy checklist, nor is it a one-time awareness raising initiative, but a commitment and implementation challenge. The proposed framework is a starting point for additional empirical tests and for the real testing in organisations, subject to confirmation of the fieldwork documentation.

Declarations

Data availability: The analysis is based on the author collected responses.

Ethics and informed consent: Verbal consent was taken.

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